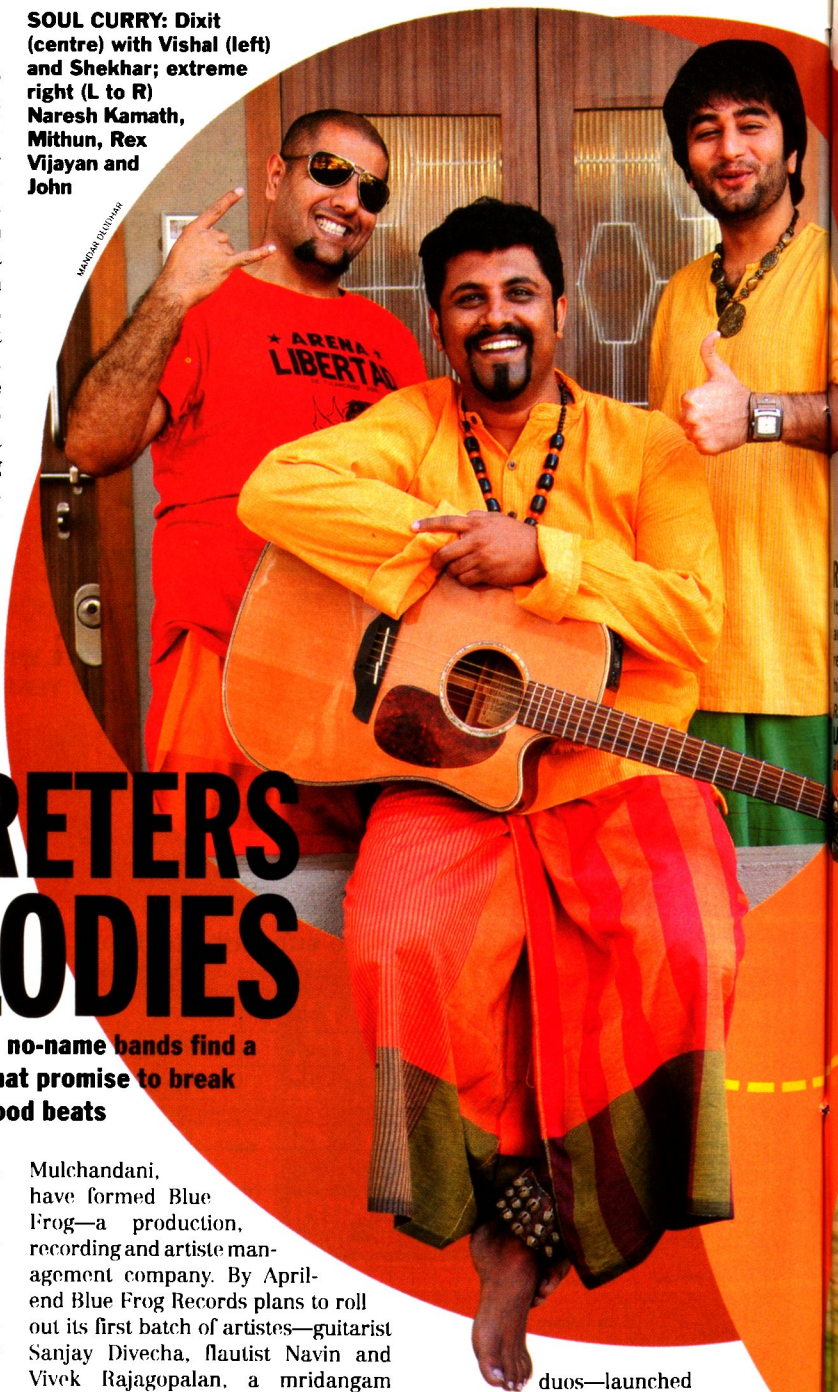


■ By Jhilmil Motihar

Within three days of hitting racks on February 8, Avial's self-titled debut album sold 1,500 CDs and was soon out of stock at a number of music stores in Mumbai. Avial isn't the name of a Bollywood music director, nor is it the title of an Indipop album or the first record of a reality show winner. Synonymous with a vegetable curry dish from Kerala, Avial is the name of the country's first "alternative Malyalee rock band". Based in Thiruvananthapuram, the five-member band took shape in 2003 but it took them five long years to get a record out. "We knew none of the big music companies would be interested. So we planned to release it on our own," says lead singer Tony John. While the big fish did stay away, a small label, Phat Phish Records, yanked Avial from Kerala and put them on stage. This is not the first time that a small artiste with big talent has found their support. Rabbi Shergill was rejected by music majors

SOUL CURRY: Dixit (centre) with Vishal (left) and Shekhar; extreme right (L to R) Naresh Kamath, Mithun, Rex Vijayan and John



INTERPRETERS OF MELODIES

Independent artistes and small no-name bands find a messiah in cult record labels that promise to break the drudgery of routine Bollywood beats

for six years till Phat Phish released his album *Rabbi*.

Rabbi became a singing superstar, but remained an exception. But now with small labels promoting new talent, 2008 may as well be the year of the independent artiste. "There had for long been frustration over nothing new being available. That bubble has burst now," says Ashutosh Phatak, of the music director duo Dhruv and Ashu who are scoring the music for the forthcoming Bollywood films, *Chandni Chouk to China* and *Drona*. They along with partners Srila Chatterjee, Mahesh Mathai and Simran

Mulchandani, have formed Blue Frog—a production, recording and artiste management company. By April-end Blue Frog Records plans to roll out its first batch of artistes—guitarist Sanjay Divecha, flautist Navin and Vivek Rajagopalan, a mridangam player, who has worked with Lucky Ali in the past.

"It's time that a non-Bollywood market was developed," says Vishal Dadlani, who along with composer partner Shekhar Ravjiani—currently one of Bollywood's most successful

duos—launched Vishal and Shekhar Music, through which they plan to promote new artistes. Their first launch, Raghu Dixit, is a testament to their motto. A trained Bharatanatyam dancer, Dixit had, for nine years, been composing and performing songs in